

The Evidence Vacuum

A Week 2 Operator brief on building an applicant-controlled evidence service for informal Mexican merchants

ROLE	ATTACK	NON-NEGOTIABLE SHADOW
Operator	Applicant-side Evidence	No association-derived fields

1. My angle

Applicant acquisition without institutional acceptance creates false hope. Before User #1, a participating lender must approve the evidence schema, assign a human reviewer, commit to reviewing 20 compliant packets, and return coded outcomes. Without those commitments, the product is document theater.

The first user is an informal merchant with at least six months of verifiable activity whose sales evidence is fragmented across receipts, payment records, supplier documents, and messages. Compartamos is a plausible pilot partner because it already serves home-based, ambulant, and catalogue businesses through advisor calls and visits. [Compartamos eligibility](#)

- Day 1: confirm eligibility and consent; organize allowlisted evidence; identify gaps or contradictions; run a private affordability teach-back.
- At 100 users: two operators, no more than four new cases per operator daily.
- Queue stop: pause onboarding at ten unresolved cases or after 48 hours without institutional action.
- First failure: operator verification, because informal evidence is inconsistent and difficult to authenticate.
- Success: movement from insufficient evidence to meaningful human underwriting review - not approval alone.

2. The technology, honestly

Current document-processing tools can extract text, tables, key-value pairs, dates, and amounts; normalize fields; ground outputs in source documents; and route low-confidence extractions for human review. [Google Document AI](#) and [Microsoft document analysis](#).

Extraction confidence is not evidence credibility. These tools cannot reliably prove that a cash transaction occurred, authenticate every receipt or WhatsApp exchange, reconcile every contradiction, predict whether the lender will accept the packet, or decide whether borrowing improves the applicant's welfare. AI structures and flags; humans verify. The system produces no credit score, applicant rank, approval probability, or lender recommendation.

3. The world's best attempts

MODEL	WHAT TRANSFERS	WHAT REMAINS
India Account Aggregators	Explicit, revocable, auditable consent; minimize custody; applicant-controlled release.	Does not cover much mixed-format informal evidence.
Brazil Open Finance	Source-authenticated, customer-authorized exchange between regulated institutions.	Cash, paper records, and informal messages remain off-rail.
Experian Affordability Passport	Consent-based categorization of income, spending, and disposable income.	Bank-visible and lender-oriented; cannot represent all informal activity.

Mexico's Fintech Law contemplates customer-authorized transactional-data sharing through APIs, but cash sales, paper receipts, supplier relationships, and informal messages remain outside institutional rails. The product must be a temporary human bridge, not a copy of an entirely digital system. [Fintech Law, Article 76](#)

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4. The Evidence vacuum

The product is an independent, applicant-controlled evidence service. It organizes and verifies evidence but never decides creditworthiness.

1	Confirm published lender eligibility and the institution's pilot commitments.
2	Obtain independent informed consent and collect only evidence permitted by the agreed schema.
3	Extract and normalize relevant fields while retaining source and transformation provenance.
4	Route uncertainty, contradictions, and possible fraud to an operator.
5	Create a locked packet, release it only with applicant authorization, and receive a coded outcome.

Retention: raw evidence is deleted seven days after the coded decision or 45 days after intake, whichever comes first. Kill condition: if the lender refuses the schema, human review, or coded reporting, no applicants are recruited and no evidence is collected.

5. The shadow

The Golden Elephant's harm is association-based judgment. Evidence collection must not become a new scoring system, so a predefined field whitelist is applied before lender access.

PERMITTED	PROHIBITED
Transaction date, amount, category, payment status, operating history, and provenance.	Contacts, family behavior, social graphs, neighborhood proxies, writing style, response speed, unrelated communications, and inferred personal traits.

- Raw conversations never enter the lender packet; third-party identities are redacted.
- The applicant-side affordability warning is never visible to or used by the lender.
- Two failed private teach-backs trigger a 24-hour pause and block packet transmission.
- If a lender demands association-derived fields, the pilot ends before recruitment.

6. Opening position

I disagree with the provocation as written. Algorithmic scoring may expand access beyond an exclusionary status quo, but increased approvals do not necessarily mean increased welfare. Without applicant-controlled evidence, explanation, repair, affordability protection, and limits on association-derived inference, automation scales both inclusion and unchallengeable error.

Why I returned from Association Defense

Association Defense was more faithful to the story, but an independent Operator cannot verify association-based harm without access to production feature lineage. Evidence is the stronger first attack because its Day 1 workflow is controllable and testable. Association Defense survives as a non-negotiable shadow constraint: the service solves today's evidence gap without deepening tomorrow's association harm.

Source notes

[Reserve Bank of India - Account Aggregators](#) | [Banco Central do Brasil - Open Finance](#) | [Experian Affordability Passport](#) | [Compartamos eligibility](#)